SOCIOECONOMIC FALSE BELIEF #28 · JOB LOSS AND SETBACKS

"Others must think I'm useless."

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Where it often comes from

After a setback, we often imagine what other people are saying. A family member's silence, a former coworker's awkward pause, or a friend's "So what are you doing now?" can feel like judgment. If we grew up in a family where reputation mattered, the fear of being seen as a failure can be stronger than the loss itself.

What Scripture teaches

Scripture warns that the fear of man is a snare, but whoever trusts in the Lord is set securely on high. Paul asks, "Am I now seeking the approval of men, or of God?" and says that we are approved by God, who examines our hearts. The psalmist says, "The LORD is on my side; I will not be afraid. What can man do to me?" This is not a call to ignore people. It is an invitation to anchor our worth in God's view, which is steadier than anyone's opinion.

> *"Am I now seeking the approval of men, or of God? Or am I striving to please men? If I were still trying to please men, I would not be a servant of Christ"* (Galatians 1:10).

Also see

> "The fear of man is a snare, but whoever trusts in the LORD is set securely on high" (Proverbs 29:25).

> "The LORD is on my side; I will not be afraid. What can man do to me?" (Psalm 118:6).

> "Instead, we speak as those approved by God to be entrusted with the gospel, not in order to please men but God, who examines our hearts" (1 Thessalonians 2:4).

> "I praise You, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made. Marvelous are Your works, and I know this very well" (Psalm 139:14).

Common self-statements

- Everyone thinks I am a failure.
- People are talking about me.
- They are being polite, but they pity me.
- I cannot face anyone I know.
- I have lost everyone's respect.
- They are better than me now.

Common logical errors

- Mind reading: Assuming I know what others think.
- Spotlight effect: Believing everyone is focused on my situation.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling ashamed and concluding that people look down on me.
- Personalization: Reading neutral comments as judgment.

Challenging questions

- What have people actually said to me, as opposed to what I imagine?
- Who has treated me with kindness since this happened?

- Would I think a friend was useless in my situation?
- Whose approval matters most to me, and why?
- What does God say about my worth?
- What would help me face people with less shame?

Truth summary

> I cannot read other people's minds, and most people are more focused on their own lives than on mine. God's view of me has not changed. I can trust Him instead of fearing others' opinions and let kind people help.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Guilt/Shame
- Fear
- Self-Esteem, Low
- Trust
- Pride

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Unemployment

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Voice of Truth — Casting Crowns
Test accusing or frightening messages against God's truth.

You Say — Lauren Daigle
God's loving assessment challenges identity based only on weakness or feelings.

Who Am I — Casting Crowns
Being known and cared for by God rests on His love rather than personal importance.

Jesus Loves Me — Gaither Vocal Band
This familiar hymn places confidence in Jesus' love rather than personal strength.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "Others must think I'm useless"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"Others must think I'm useless." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What have people actually said?
- ☐ Who has been kind to me?
- ☐ What would I think of a friend in my place?
- ☐ Whose approval do I most want?
- ☐ What does God think of me?
- ☐ What simple answer can I prepare?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I do not know what others think.
- ☐ The fear of man is a snare.
- ☐ God's approval is steady.
- ☐ Most people are focused on their own lives.
- ☐ Kind people are around me.
- ☐ I can face others with honesty.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ **Galatians 1:10**
  "Am I now seeking the approval of men, or of God? Or am I striving to please men? If I were still trying to please men, I would not be a servant of Christ."
- ☐ **Proverbs 29:25**
  "The fear of man is a snare, but whoever trusts in the LORD is set securely on high."
- ☐ **Psalm 118:6**
  "The LORD is on my side; I will not be afraid. What can man do to me?"

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ Imagined and actual: Each week, write one thing you imagined people thought and what they actually said or did.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.
  For example, Psalm 118:6 becomes: "Sarah can write: "The Lord is on my side, so I do not have to fear what others think.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Fear" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

This card is educational and is not financial or legal advice. Choose steps you can do safely. If you are without food, housing, or safety, contact your church, a trusted advisor, or local assistance services.

- ☐ Check the evidence. List what people have actually said or done since the job loss.
- ☐ Reach out to one kind person. Contact someone who has been supportive and tell them what you are facing.
- ☐ Practice a simple answer. Write one honest sentence for "What are you doing now?"
- ☐ Pray Psalm 118:6. Read it aloud before a hard conversation.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "Others must think I'm useless": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A kind response
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~Others must think I'm useless.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, You see me as I am. When I fear what others think, steady me with Your approval. Help me answer honestly and receive kindness from the people You send. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.